

The Cop and the Anthem

O. Henry · 1904

First published: New York Sunday World, Dec 1904

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Four_Million/The_Cop_and_the_Anthem (revision 14232999), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Cop and the Anthem suggest about homelessness and society?
- What does The Cop and the Anthem suggest about fate and irony?
- What does The Cop and the Anthem suggest about redemption?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the

app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Cop and the Anthem	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*homelessness and society* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Cop and the Anthem

Author biography

O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910.

Historical and cultural context

Around 1900 the homeless men of New York's parks faced brutal winters. "The Island" was Blackwell's Island (now Roosevelt Island) in the East River, site of a workhouse and prison where petty offenders served short terms; for some, a winter there meant food and shelter.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in the New York World in December 1904; collected in The Four Million (1906).

Then: Popular with O. Henry's large newspaper audience.

Now: Taught for its situational irony and its satire of a society in which jail is the only shelter for the poor.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Soapy, a homeless man, decides to get himself arrested so he can spend the winter on the Island. He tries crime after crime.

Main themes

- irony of fate.
- poverty and society.
- redemption.

Why it matters

The story satirizes how society treats the poor and asks whether people get the chance to change.

Spoilers · teacher only

Every attempt fails. Moved by an organ anthem outside a church, he resolves to reform and find work, and at that moment a policeman arrests him for loitering; he gets three months on the Island.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Cop and the Anthem: Have you ever gotten exactly what you wanted at exactly the wrong moment?
Prompt: Before we open The Cop and the Anthem: Have you ever gotten exactly what you wanted at exactly the wrong moment?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

situational irony; satire; diction; Blackwell's Island.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910. The world of the book. Around 1900 the homeless men of New York's parks faced brutal winters. "The Island" was Blackwell's Island (now Roosevelt Island) in the East River, site of a workhouse and prison where petty offenders served short terms; for some, a winter there meant food and shelter. Publication and reception. First published in the New York World in December 1904; collected in The Four Million (1906). Then: Popular with O. Henry's large newspaper audience. Now: Taught for its situational irony and its satire of a society in which jail is the only shelter for the poor.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"Three months on the Island" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4). Soapy's wish, then his sentence.

> *Three months on the Island (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4)*

Think-aloud: "Three months on the Island" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4). Soapy's wish, then his sentence.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Soapy, a homeless man, decides to get himself arrested so he can spend the winter on the Island. He tries crime after crime. Themes to track: irony of fate.: poverty and society.: redemption.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Cop and the Anthem: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Cop and the Anthem still matter? The story satirizes how society treats the poor and asks whether people get the chance to change.
Anchor question: Why might The Cop and the Anthem still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story satirizes how society treats the poor and asks whether people get the chance to change.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Explain the irony of the ending. Answer: When Soapy wants to be arrested, he can't be; when he resolves to reform, he is.
Exit ticket: Explain the irony of the ending.
Answer: When Soapy wants to be arrested, he can't be; when he resolves to reform, he is.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Cop and the Anthem.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "O. Henry" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/O-Henry); NCpedia, "Porter, William Sydney (O. Henry)" (https://www.ncpedia.org/biography/porter-william-sydney); O. Henry Museum (Austin) (https://www.austintexas.gov/department/o-henry-museum); NYC Parks, Roosevelt Island history (https://www.nycgovparks.org/)

Lesson 2: The Cop and the Anthem

Focus: a reversal that punishes a change of heart

Content note (homelessness, petty crime): Sensitive content: Homelessness; petty crime. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes homelessness; petty crime.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Soapy, a homeless man in Madison Square, wants three warm months in jail on Blackwell's Island for the winter. He tries to get arrested: skipping a restaurant bill, breaking a window, harassing a woman, disturbing the peace, stealing an umbrella. Every attempt fails. Moved by church music, he resolves to reform and find work, and at that moment a policeman arrests him for loitering; he gets three months.

Background: Published in 1904. Blackwell's Island (now Roosevelt Island) held New York's workhouse and jail.

Significance: A neat cycle of situational irony that also comments on poverty and policing.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why might someone prefer jail to life on the street? What does that say about the society? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to redemption because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes homelessness; petty crime.
Prompt: Why might someone prefer jail to life on the street? What does that say about the society?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to redemption because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the anthem awakens his conscience.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: loitered — lingered; hung about; congenial — pleasant and well suited; roasted — cook with dry heat, usually in an oven; tickets — printed cards used in a game; scorned — look down on with disdain.
Words: loitered: lingered; hung about · congenial: pleasant and well suited · roasted: cook with dry heat, usually in an oven · tickets: printed cards used in a game · scorned: look down on with disdain

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1904. Blackwell's Island (now Roosevelt Island) held New York's workhouse and jail. A neat cycle of situational irony that also comments on poverty and policing. Irony: Every crime fails; innocence is punished. Diction / vocabulary: Ornate vocabulary ("hegira," "Arcadia") gives a comic grandeur to Soapy's plans. Structure: A series of attempts, each foiled, builds to the reversal. Watch for the anthem: memory of his better past and a call to change.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4). His goal. That is irony at work: Every crime fails; innocence is punished.

> *Three months on the Island was what his soul craved* (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4)

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4). His goal. That is irony at work: Every crime fails; innocence is punished.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Arcadia is an ideal paradise; calling a prison that shows how desperate Soapy is. Ask: How does this line connect to redemption? Expected: The anthem awakens his conscience. (Ironic grandeur.)

> *In his fancy the Island seemed an unattainable Arcadia* (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 30)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Arcadia is an ideal paradise; calling a prison that shows how desperate Soapy is.
Ask: How does this line connect to redemption?
Expected answer: The anthem awakens his conscience. (Ironic grandeur.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for irony, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Cop and the Anthem develops the idea of a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. When the text says "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4), it shows this directly. Soapy's soul "craved" "Three months on the Island," and he fails to get it by crime, but once he resolves to reform, "the Magistrate" gives him exactly that.

Task: Annotate the story for irony, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Cop and the Anthem develops the idea of a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. When the text says "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4), it shows this directly. Soapy's soul "craved" "Three months on the Island," and he fails to get it by crime, but once he resolves to reform, "the Magistrate" gives him exactly that.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Why might someone prefer jail to life on the street? What does that say about the society? Ask: is the ending funny or tragic?

Anchor question: Why might someone prefer jail to life on the street? What does that say about the society?

Facilitation: Ask: is the ending funny or tragic?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. ("Three months on the Island was what his soul craved", The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. ("Three months on the Island was what his soul craved", The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how irony shapes a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Key takeaway: the anthem awakens his conscience.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** Every crime fails; innocence is punished.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Ornate vocabulary ("hegira," "Arcadia") gives a comic grandeur to Soapy's plans.
- **Structure:** A series of attempts, each foiled, builds to the reversal.

Themes and how they develop

- **redemption:** the anthem awakens his conscience.

Symbols and motifs

- **the anthem:** memory of his better past and a call to change.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Three months on the Island was what his soul craved” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4) His goal.
- “In his fancy the Island seemed an unattainable Arcadia” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 30) Ironic grandeur.
- “Three months on the Island,” said the Magistrate” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 48) The ending.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose.
Evidence: “Three months on the Island was what his soul craved” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4)
Reasoning: Soapy's soul "craved" "Three months on the Island," and he fails to get it by crime, but once he resolves to reform, "the Magistrate" gives him exactly that.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
loitered (verb)	lingered; hung about	*Through one violet-stained window a soft light glowed, where, no doubt, the organist loitered over the keys, making sure of his mastery of the coming Sabbath anthem.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
congenial (adjective)	pleasant and well suited		

		Three months of assured board and bed and congenial company, safe from Boreas and bluecoats, seemed to Soapy the essence of things desirable.	Student look-up (not yet verified)
roasted (verb)	cook with dry heat, usually in an oven	*A roasted mallard duck, thought Soapy, would be about the thing—with a bottle of Chablis, and then Camembert, a demi-tasse and a cigar.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
tickets (noun)	printed cards used in a game	*Just as his more fortunate fellow New Yorkers had bought their tickets to Palm Beach and the Riviera each winter, so Soapy had made his humbler arrangements for his annual hegira to the Island.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
scorned (verb)	look down on with disdain	*He scorned the provisions made in the name of charity for the city's dependents.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
conjunction (noun)	partnership; combination	*The conjunction of Soapy's receptive state of mind and the influences about the old church wrought a sudden and wonderful change in his soul.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pitched (verb)	settled on; chose	*Neatly upon his left ear on the callous pavement two waiters pitched Soapy.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
impudent (adjective)	marked by casual disrespect	*He made eyes at her, was taken with sudden coughs and "hems," smiled, smirked and went brazenly through the impudent and contemptible litany of the "masher."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
declaring (verb)	state emphatically and authoritatively	*The pleasantest was to dine luxuriously at some expensive restaurant; and then, after declaring insolvency, be handed over quietly and without uproar to a policeman.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
motives (noun)	reasons for doing something	*He viewed with swift horror the pit into which he had tumbled, the degraded days, unworthy desires, dead hopes, wrecked faculties and base motives that made up his existence.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why might someone prefer jail to life on the street? What does that say about the society?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with homelessness and society?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Soapy want for the winter? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Three months in jail on the Island
2. What happens when Soapy breaks a store window? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: The policeman chases another man
3. What makes Soapy decide to change his life? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Church organ music, an anthem
4. What does Soapy resolve to do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Find work and reform
5. What finally happens? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: He is arrested and sentenced to three months
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Cop and the Anthem" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Soapy, a homeless man in Madison Square, wants three warm months in jail on Blackwell's Island for the winter. He tries to get arrested: skipping a restaurant bill, breaking a window, harassing a woman, disturbing the peace, stealing an umbrella. Every attempt fails. Moved by church music, he resolves to reform and find work, and at that moment a policeman arrests him for loitering; he gets three…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Cop and the Anthem"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Cop and the Anthem" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Through one violet-stained window a soft light glowed, where, no doubt, the organist loitered over the keys, making sure of his mastery of the coming Sabbath anthem." What does "loitered" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: loitered: lingered; hung about.
10. Reread: "Three months of assured board and bed and congenial company, safe from Boreas and bluecoats, seemed to Soapy the essence of things desirable." What does "congenial" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: congenial: pleasant and well suited.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Cop and the Anthem" suggest about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A neat cycle of situational irony that also comments on poverty and policing.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4): His goal. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “The hibernatorial ambitions of Soapy were not of the highest.”, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Cop and the Anthem”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Soapy, a homeless man in Madison Square, wants three warm months in jail on Blackwell's Island for the winter. He tries to get arrested: skipping a restaurant bill, breaking a window, harassing a woman, disturbing the peace, stealing an umbrella. Every attempt fails. Moved by church music, he…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Cop and the Anthem” set up that the rest of The Cop and the Anthem will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: “In his fancy the Island seemed an unattainable Arcadia” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 30): Ironic grandeur. On structure: A series of attempts, each foiled, builds to the reversal. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: “Three months on the Island,” said the Magistrate” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 48): The ending. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Why might someone prefer jail to life on the street? What does that say about the society?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with homelessness and society? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: “Three months on the Island was what his soul craved” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4): His goal. On diction / vocabulary: Ornate vocabulary ("hegira," "Arcadia") gives a comic grandeur to Soapy's plans. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1904. Blackwell's Island (now Roosevelt Island) held New York's workhouse and jail. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: “In his fancy the Island seemed an unattainable Arcadia” (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 30): Ironic grandeur. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A neat cycle of situational irony that also comments on poverty and policing." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island," said the Magistrate" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 48): The ending. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4): His goal. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Cop and the Anthem" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "In his fancy the Island seemed an unattainable Arcadia" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 30): Ironic grandeur. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Cop and the Anthem": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island," said the Magistrate" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 48): The ending. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to fate and irony: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4): His goal. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the

poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "In his fancy the Island seemed an unattainable Arcadia" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 30): Ironic grandeur. On irony: Every crime fails; innocence is punished. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how "The Cop and the Anthem" treats a reversal that punishes a change of heart with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Cop and the Anthem see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island," said the Magistrate" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 48): The ending. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve homelessness and society? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island was what his soul craved" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 4): His goal. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a reversal that punishes a change of heart? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "In his fancy the Island seemed an unattainable Arcadia" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 30): Ironic grandeur. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: O. Henry uses irony to show that society punishes the poor regardless of what they choose. Useful evidence: "Three months on the Island," said the Magistrate" (The Cop and the Anthem, paragraph 48): The ending. Theme link: the anthem awakens his conscience. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz

1. What does Soapy want for the winter?
   A. A job
   B. A room at a hotel
   C. Three months in jail on the Island
   D. A train ticket south
2. What happens when Soapy breaks a store window?
   A. He is arrested
   B. The owner thanks him
   C. He runs away
   D. The policeman chases another man
3. What makes Soapy decide to change his life?
   A. A sermon
   B. A letter
   C. Church organ music, an anthem
   D. A friend's advice
4. What does Soapy resolve to do?
   A. Leave New York
   B. Return home
   C. Steal a coat
   D. Find work and reform
5. What finally happens?
   A. He is given a coat
   B. He goes south
   C. He is arrested and sentenced to three months
   D. He gets a job
6. In the line “Through one violet-stained window a soft light glowed, where, no doubt, the organist loitered over the keys, making sure of his mastery of the coming Sabbath anthem.”, what does “loitered” most nearly mean?
   A. lingered; hung about
   B. cook with dry heat, usually in an oven
   C. pleasant and well suited
   D. printed cards used in a game
7. In the line “Three months of assured board and bed and congenial company, safe from Boreas and bluecoats, seemed to Soapy the essence of things desirable.”, what does “congenial” most nearly mean?
   A. lingered; hung about
   B. cook with dry heat, usually in an oven
   C. printed cards used in a game
   D. pleasant and well suited

Answer key: 1. C (Three months in jail on the Island); 2. D (The policeman chases another man); 3. C (Church organ music, an anthem); 4. D (Find work and reform); 5. C (He is arrested and sentenced to three months); 6. A (lingered; hung about); 7. D (pleasant and well suited)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Cop and the Anthem," how does Henry show a reversal that punishes a change of heart? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Cop and the Anthem, how does Henry develop the idea of a reversal that punishes a change of heart? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Cop and the Anthem develops the idea of a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Cop and the Anthem (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Cop and the Anthem suggests about a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in The Cop and the Anthem to complicate the reader's understanding of a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Cop and the Anthem within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a reversal that punishes a change of heart responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Cop and the Anthem alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a reversal that punishes a change of heart follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Cop and the Anthem and its treatment of a reversal that punishes a change of heart. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Cop and the Anthem as evidence for a larger claim about a reversal that punishes a change of heart in The Cop and the Anthem. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Cop and the Anthem as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a reversal that punishes a change of heart. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Cop and the Anthem.

SAT-style questions

1. *A roasted mallard duck, thought Soapy, would be about the thing—with a bottle of Chablis, and then Camembert, a demi-tasse and a cigar.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “roasted” most nearly mean?

   A. marked by casual disrespect

   B. cook with dry heat, usually in an oven

   C. state emphatically and authoritatively

   D. reasons for doing something

2. *The hibernatorial ambitions of Soapy were not of the highest. In them there were no considerations of Mediterranean cruises, of soporific Southern skies or drifting in the Vesuvian Bay. Three months on the Island was what his soul craved. Three months of assured board and bed and congenial company, safe from Boreas and bluecoats, seemed to Soapy the essence of things desirable.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Cop and the Anthem”?

   A. A story so convincing it becomes real

   B. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

   C. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

   D. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

SAT key: 1. B (cook with dry heat, usually in an oven); 2. C (A reversal that punishes a change of heart)

Whole-book test

The Cop and the Anthem: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What does Soapy want for the winter?
   A. A job
   B. A room at a hotel
   C. Three months in jail on the Island
   D. A train ticket south
2. What happens when Soapy breaks a store window?
   A. He is arrested
   B. The owner thanks him
   C. He runs away
   D. The policeman chases another man
3. What makes Soapy decide to change his life?
   A. A sermon
   B. A letter
   C. Church organ music, an anthem
   D. A friend's advice
4. What does Soapy resolve to do?
   A. Leave New York
   B. Return home
   C. Steal a coat
   D. Find work and reform
5. What finally happens?
   A. He is given a coat
   B. He goes south
   C. He is arrested and sentenced to three months
   D. He gets a job
6. In the line “Through one violet-stained window a soft light glowed, where, no doubt, the organist loitered over the keys, making sure of his mastery of the coming Sabbath anthem.”, what does “loitered” most nearly mean?
   A. lingered; hung about
   B. cook with dry heat, usually in an oven
   C. pleasant and well suited
   D. printed cards used in a game

7. In the line “Three months of assured board and bed and congenial company, safe from Boreas and bluecoats, seemed to Soapy the essence of things desirable.”, what does “congenial” most nearly mean?
   A. lingered; hung about
   B. cook with dry heat, usually in an oven
   C. printed cards used in a game
   D. pleasant and well suited
8. As used in the story (“Through one violet-stained window a soft light glowed, where, no doubt, the organist loitered over the keys, making sure of his mastery of t”), what does “loitered” mean?
   A. lingered; hung about
   B. look down on with disdain
   C. marked by casual disrespect
   D. pleasant and well suited
9. As used in the story (“Three months of assured board and bed and congenial company, safe from Boreas and bluecoats, seemed to Soapy the essence of things desirable”), what does “congenial” mean?
   A. partnership; combination
   B. pleasant and well suited
   C. state emphatically and authoritatively
   D. cook with dry heat, usually in an oven
10. As used in the story (“A roasted mallard duck, thought Soapy, would be about the thing—with a bottle of Chablis, and then Camembert, a demi-tasse and a cigar.”), what does “roasted” mean?
    A. settled on; chose
    B. reasons for doing something
    C. cook with dry heat, usually in an oven
    D. printed cards used in a game
11. As used in the story (“Just as his more fortunate fellow New Yorkers had bought their tickets to Palm Beach and the Riviera each winter, so Soapy had made his humb”), what does “tickets” mean?
    A. marked by casual disrespect
    B. lingered; hung about
    C. look down on with disdain
    D. printed cards used in a game
12. As used in the story (“He scorned the provisions made in the name of charity for the city’s dependents.”), what does “scorned” mean?
    A. look down on with disdain
    B. state emphatically and authoritatively
    C. pleasant and well suited
    D. partnership; combination

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how homelessness and society develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how fate and irony develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how redemption develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (homelessness and society, fate and irony, redemption) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (Three months in jail on the Island); 2. D (The policeman chases another man); 3. C (Church organ music, an anthem); 4. D (Find work and reform); 5. C (He is arrested and sentenced to three months); 6. A (lingered; hung about); 7. D (pleasant and well suited); 8. A (lingered; hung about); 9. B (pleasant and well suited); 10. C (cook with dry heat, usually in an oven); 11. D (printed cards used in a game); 12. A (look down on with disdain)

Essay assignments

Essay: Homelessness and society

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cop and the Anthem teaches about homelessness and society. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops homelessness and society in The Cop and the Anthem. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops homelessness and society across The Cop and the Anthem. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cop and the Anthem (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of homelessness and society. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of homelessness and society in The Cop and the Anthem. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Cop and the Anthem (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of homelessness and society, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cop and the Anthem's treatment of homelessness and society in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on homelessness and society in The Cop and the Anthem that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on homelessness and society in The Cop and the Anthem. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about homelessness and society in The Cop and the Anthem, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on homelessness and society in The Cop and the Anthem, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Fate and irony

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cop and the Anthem teaches about fate and irony. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops fate and irony in The Cop and the Anthem. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops fate and irony across The Cop and the Anthem. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cop and the Anthem (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of fate and irony. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of fate and irony in The Cop and the Anthem. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Cop and the Anthem (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of fate and irony, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cop and the Anthem's treatment of fate and irony in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on fate and irony in The Cop and the Anthem that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on fate and irony in The Cop and the Anthem. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about fate and irony in The Cop and the Anthem, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on fate and irony in The Cop and the Anthem, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Redemption

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cop and the Anthem teaches about redemption. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops redemption in The Cop and the Anthem. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops redemption across The Cop and the Anthem. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cop and the Anthem (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of redemption. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of redemption in The Cop and the Anthem. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Cop and the Anthem (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of redemption, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cop and the Anthem's treatment of redemption in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on redemption in The Cop and the Anthem that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on redemption in The Cop and the Anthem. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about redemption in The Cop and the Anthem, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on redemption in The Cop and the Anthem, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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